What 1,000 Indie Startups Reveal About Building for Revenue

A data-driven briefing on domain choice, category selection, business model, and exit pricing — built for founders and the advisors who consult them.

1,000	**$133.8M**	**262**	**$86.8M**
startups analyzed	trailing 12-month revenue	actively listed for sale	combined asking value

Five decisions that separate high-revenue startups from the rest

1. **Domain extension is a revenue signal**

   .ai and .io startups post 13x and 7x the median revenue of .com startups — buyers and users read premium TLDs as a credibility cue.

2. **Category crowding ≠ category opportunity**

   AI is the single largest category (197 startups, 27% of tagged listings) yet ranks 12th of 25 on median revenue — Customer Support and Marketplace tools earn far more per startup.

3. **B2B out-earns B2C by ~4x**

   Median 12-month revenue is $8,362 for B2B vs. $2,213 for B2C — consumer audiences need much higher volume to match B2B economics.

4. **Paid-only pricing beats freemium ~6x**

   Startups with a straightforward paid model post $7,081 median revenue vs. $1,197 for freemium — free tiers are not reliably converting at this scale.

5. **Exit multiples track growth, not size**

   Startups listed for sale trade at a median 3.0x trailing revenue — but the multiple correlates with recent MRR growth (r=0.36), not with revenue size itself.

1,000 self-reported startups on the TrustMRR platform

TrustMRR verifies revenue directly from payment providers (Stripe, Paddle, etc.), giving a rare, largely audited snapshot of small and early-stage startup economics — most public revenue benchmarks rely on self-reported or estimated figures.

Reading this data responsibly

- Category is missing for 27% of records — trend reads are directional, not exhaustive.
- Revenue is heavily right-skewed: a handful of breakout stores (e.g. Stan, Supliful) lift category means well above the median — this deck leads with medians throughout.
- 262 of 1,000 startups (26%) are actively listed for sale, giving a live view of what the market pays for revenue today.

$334.0M
all-time cumulative revenue across the dataset

726
startups with a tagged category

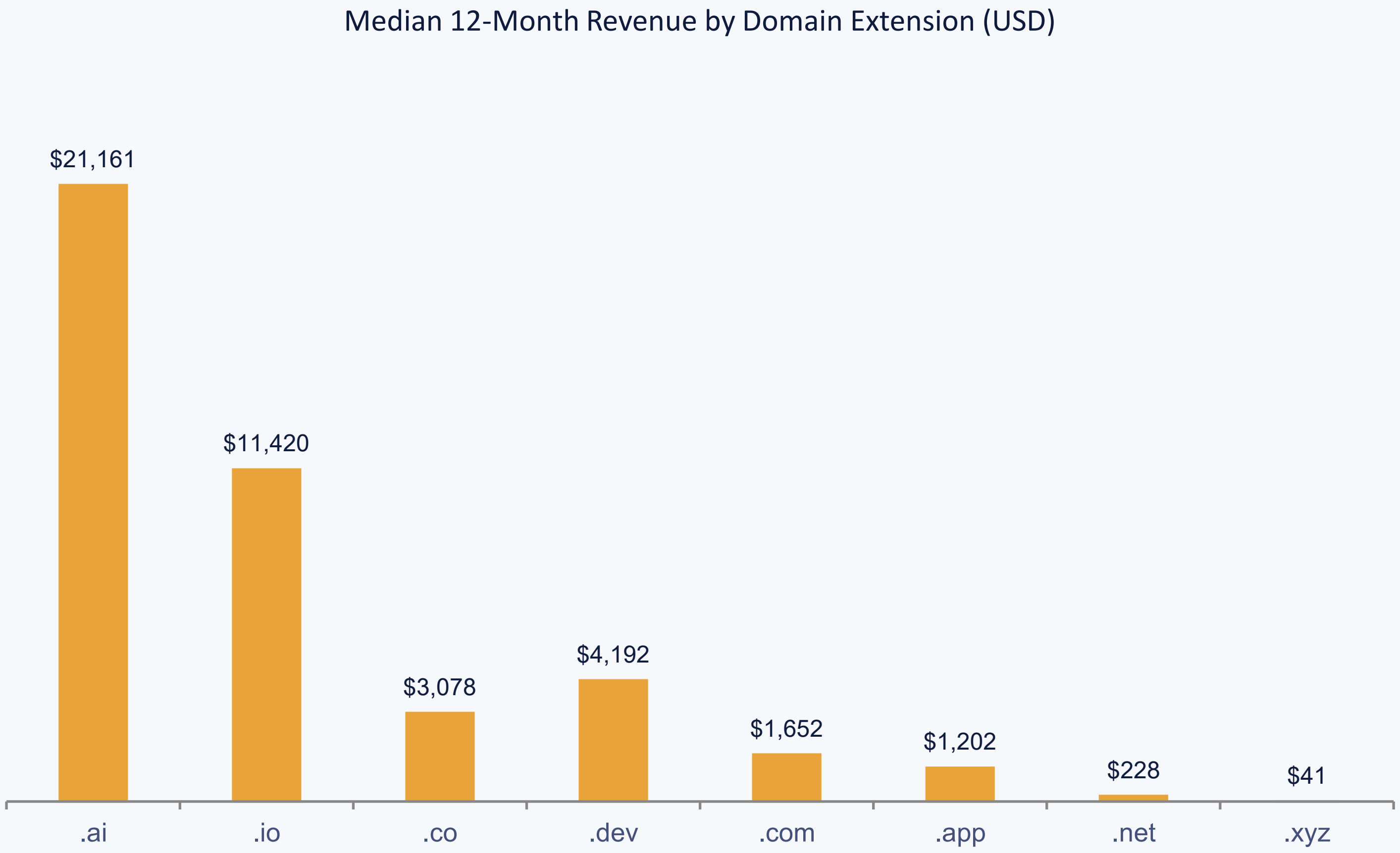
720
startups with a listed country

50+
countries represented, led by the US (258)

INSIGHT 01 · DOMAIN STRATEGY

Premium TLDs earn premium revenue

.com is still the default — 312 of 782 domains registered — but .ai and .io startups earn far more per business at the median, even at a fraction of the volume.



Sample size (n)

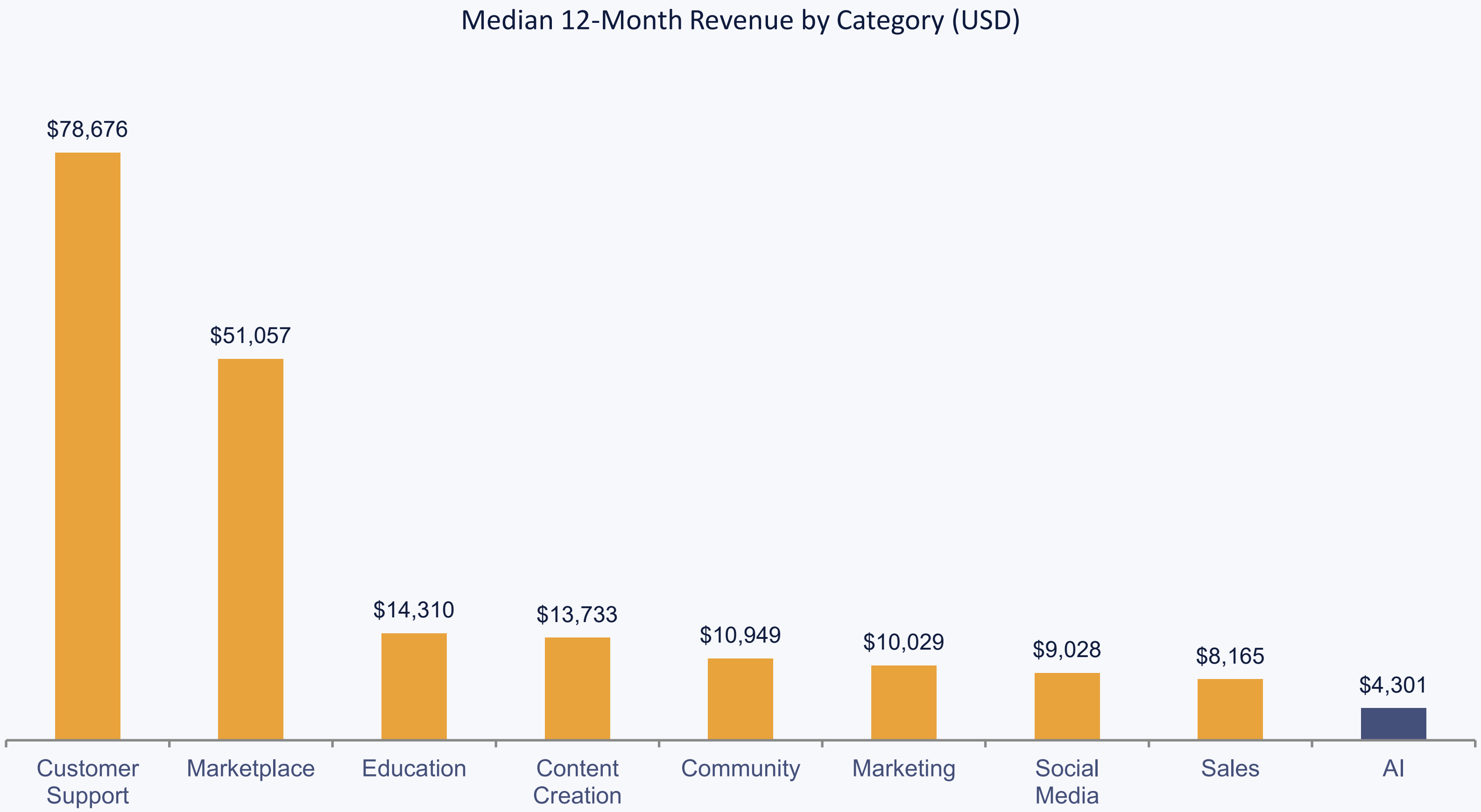
.ai	**91**
.io	**60**
.co	**22**
.dev	**13**
.com	**312**
.app	**70**
.net	**8**
.xyz	**10**

Actionable takeaway

Advise AI/SaaS founders to secure a .ai or .io domain over a generic .com — it correlates with 7–13x higher revenue and signals category credibility to buyers.

The most crowded category is not the highest-earning one

Ranked by median 12-month revenue among categories with 5+ startups. AI is called out for contrast: it is 4x more crowded than the next-largest category, yet sits well below the leaders.



197

AI startups in the dataset — 27% of every tagged listing, by far the largest category.

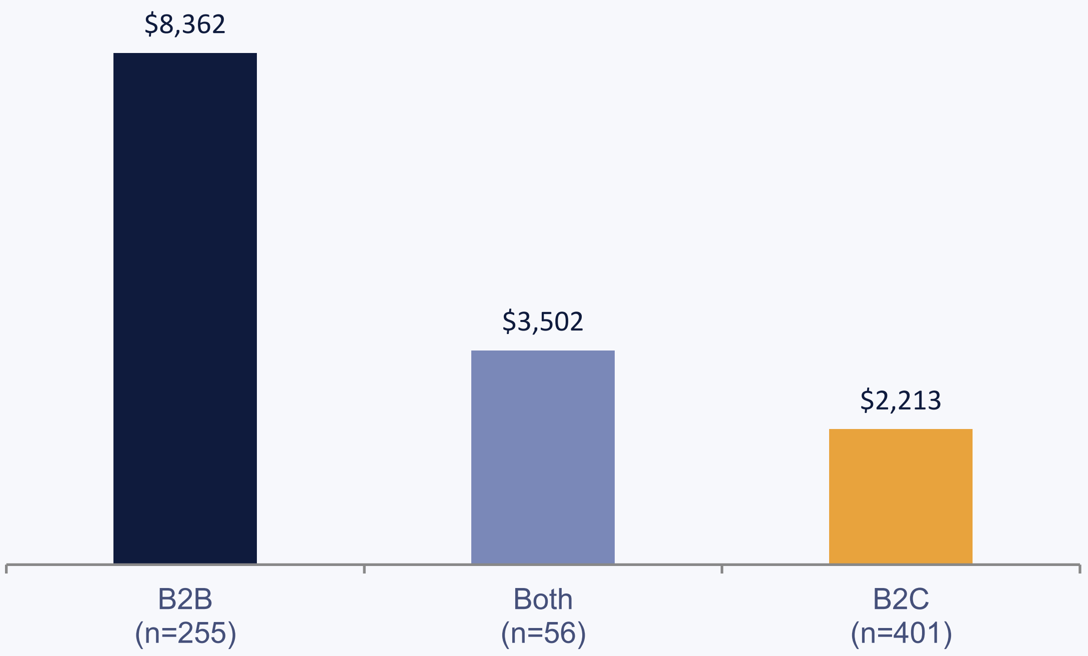
Actionable takeaway

Don't default a founder into 'AI' because it's fashionable. Support tooling, marketplaces, and education products face less competition and post higher median revenue — probe for a genuine wedge before picking the category.

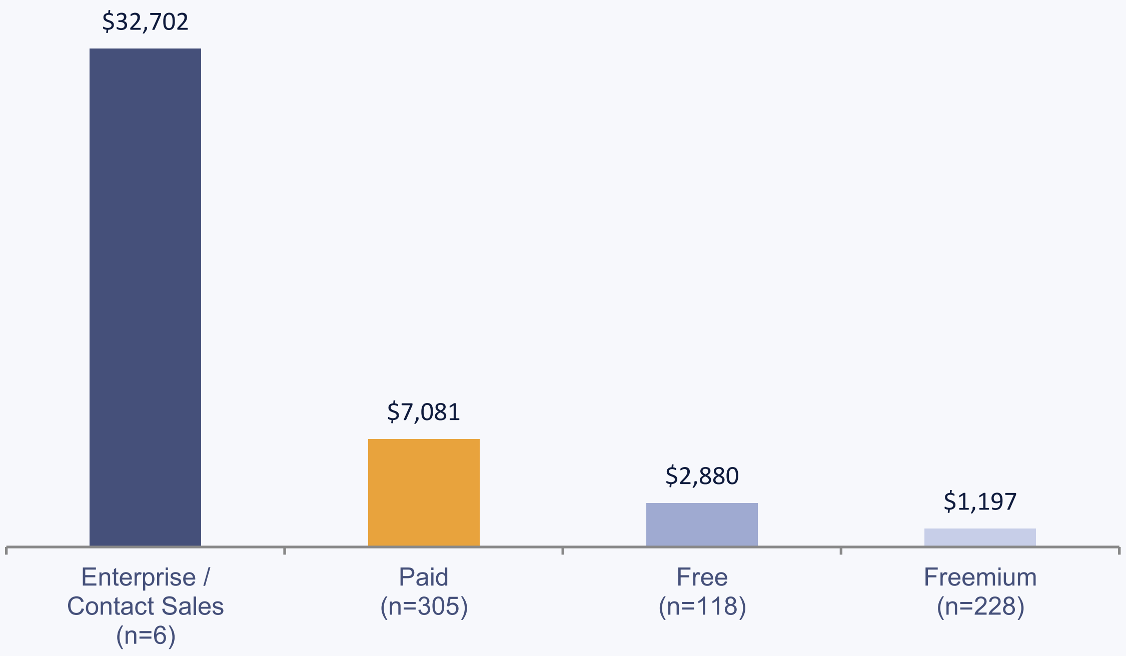
INSIGHT 03 · BUSINESS MODEL

Who you sell to — and how you charge — outweighs most other choices

Median 12-month revenue by audience



Median 12-month revenue by pricing approach

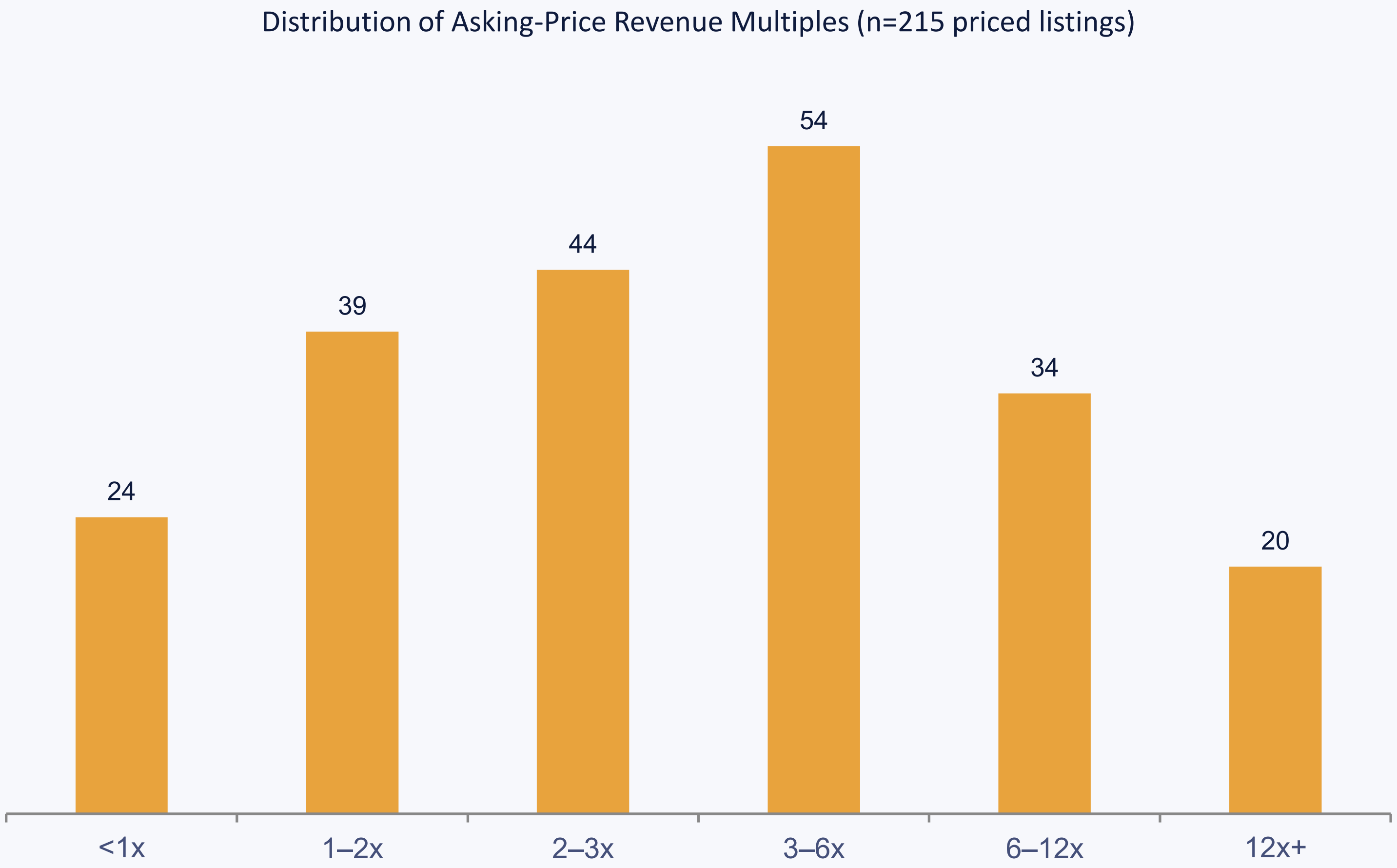


Actionable takeaway

Steer founders toward a clear B2B wedge and a straightforward paid plan from day one. Freemium is not a shortcut to revenue at this stage — it needs far more scale (and time) to pay off than a direct paid offer.

INSIGHT 04 · EXIT PRICING

The market pays ~3x trailing revenue — and pays more for growth, not size



3.0x

median asking-price multiple of trailing revenue

0.36

correlation between multiple and recent MRR growth rate

Actionable takeaway

When advising on an eventual sale, frame 2–6x trailing revenue as the realistic band — and coach founders to protect recent growth momentum, not just headline revenue, since growth is what pulls a deal into double-digit multiples.

CASE STUDY

What the top revenue earners have in common

Startup	Category	Domain	Audience	12-mo Revenue
Stan	Creator Tools	stan.store	—	$25.0M
Brand On Demand	E-comm	supliful.com	B2B	$10.6M
Stack Influence	Marketing	stackinfluence.com	B2B	$10.5M
Comp AI	AI	trycomp.ai	B2B	$3.9M
1Lookup	SaaS	1lookup.io	B2B	$3.1M
Rezi	AI	rezi.ai	B2C	$3.0M
Cometly	Analytics	cometly.com	B2B	$2.3M
Kibu	Education	kibu.com	B2B	$1.9M

**Four additional top-25 records are unnamed “Stealth Company” listings and excluded here.*

Common traits

B2B skew

6 of the top 8 named performers sell to other businesses, not consumers.

Premium or brand-first domains

Every top performer uses a clean .com, .ai, or .io — no hyphenated or generic domains.

US home base

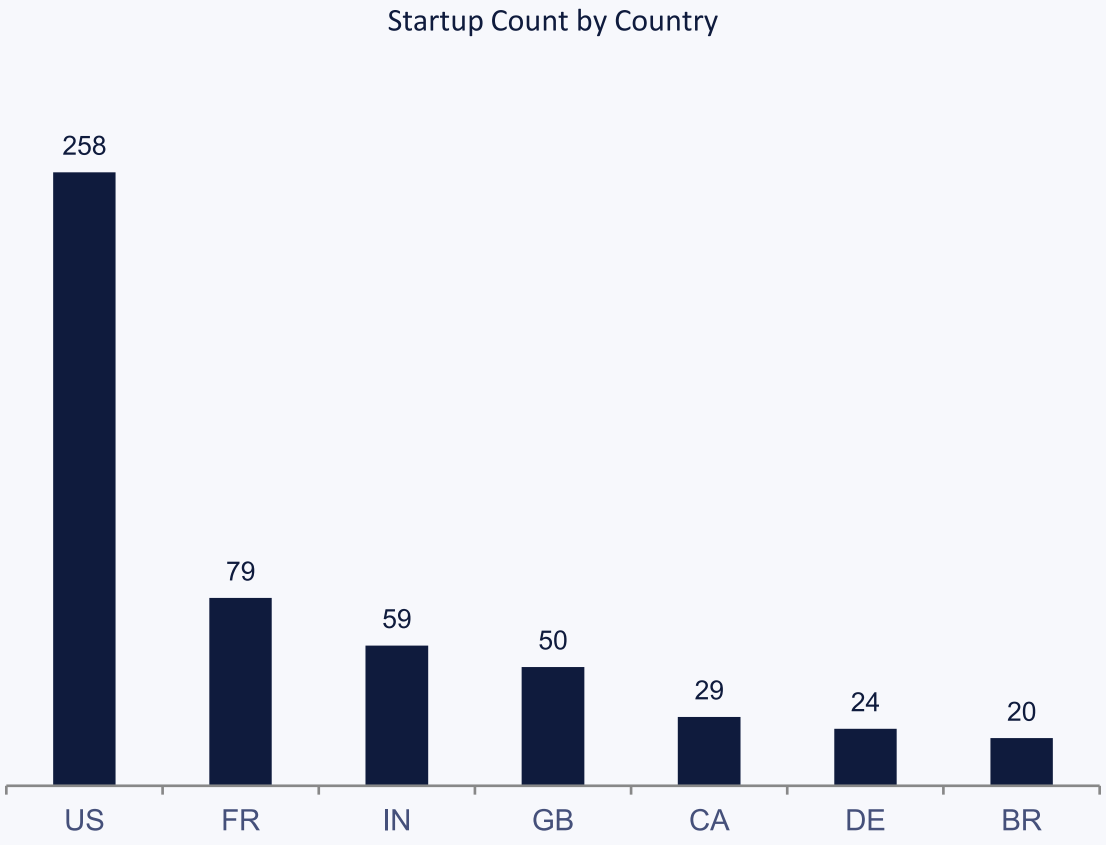
8 of the top 8 named performers are US-headquartered, reflecting the pricing power gap seen in the geographic data.

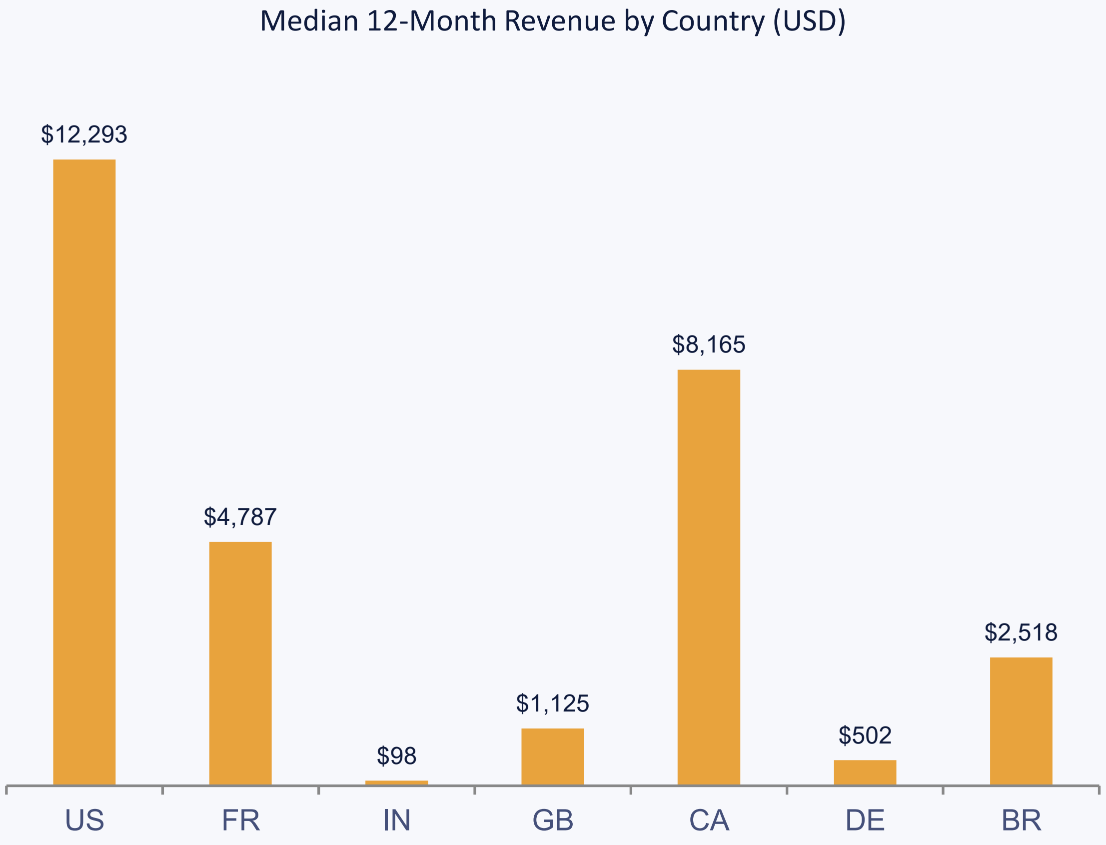
Narrow, tool-shaped positioning

Each solves one workflow (comp benchmarking, outreach, influencer payouts) rather than a broad platform promise.

Volume and revenue power don't live in the same places

Among countries with 15+ startups: the US leads on both listing volume and revenue per startup. India has the third-largest founder base but the lowest revenue per startup of any major market.





Advising a startup on positioning

Domain

Push for .ai or .io over generic .com when the category supports it — it's a low-cost signal correlated with 7–13x higher revenue.

Category

Don't default to 'AI' for its own sake. Check if the same problem fits a less crowded, higher-earning category like Support, Marketplace, or Education first.

Audience

Bias toward a B2B wedge where the product allows it — B2B revenue runs ~4x B2C at the median in this data.

Pricing

Launch with a clear paid tier rather than leading on freemium; freemium needs far more scale to match paid-model revenue.

Growth story

For anyone planning to sell, protect and document recent growth (MRR trend) — it's the strongest lever on the multiple a buyer will pay.

Geography

Factor in market-level pricing power: a US or UK audience converts to revenue very differently than similarly sized markets like India.